41-year-old Jarange-Patil's journey to the forefront of Maratha activism is a testament to his perseverance. The youngest of three brothers and a sister, Jarange-Patil grew up in crippling poverty; home ran on whatever his cane-cutter father and brothers got with back-breaking work. He cut his teeth as an agitator for the Maratha cause at a young age. Packed off to his maternal uncle's place in Jalna district, where he married a maternal cousin, Jarange-Patil continued with a peripatetic life from this base, rallying youth for the cause. He was associated with various Maratha groups, and later with the Congress, even floating an organisation called the 'Shivba Sanghatana'. The father of four and Class 12 dropout even sold off half of his four-acre plot of land to fund his endeavour.

supporters claim success, murmurs of dissent are rising within the community. A Maratha leader says Jarange-Patil has constantly shifted the goal posts during his protest—like broadening the demand from Marathas in Marathwada to Marathas across the state. "We have won on the battlefield but lost on the negotiating table," he says, adding that the draft notification could face legal hurdles.

The responses to Jarange-Patil's agitation have also exposed the fault lines within the state's three-party ruling coalition. It has given Shinde an opportunity to be his own man, since it is he who has taken the initiative to placate Jarange-Patil, in the bargain emerging as the leader of the poor, subaltern Marathas. By doing so, he has tapped into a section of the Maratha voter who would otherwise have gone with the Sharad Pawar-led parent

WHILE JARANGE-PATIL DISAVOWS POLITICAL ASPIRATIONS, THE REPERCUSSIONS OF HIS AGITATION ARE FELT ACROSS THE STATE

A long-time associate of Jarange-Patil says the trigger for him to take to protests had come when he had to give up his studies due to lack of resources. "His own poverty which made him give up education was the turning point. He had heard of leaders like the late Annasaheb Patil, Annasaheb Jawale Patil and later, Vinayak Mete, who had protested for Maratha quotas. The lack of educational opportunities, the shrinking opportunities for Marathas in jobs and the frustration at those with lesser marks getting admissions in educational institutions pushed him to the conclusion that quotas were the panacea for the community." Says a Shinde Sena leader from Marathwada: "Jarange-Patil is somebody who has lived for agitations. His humble origins and lack of any legacy or baggage helped him strike a chord with the Maratha youth. His persistence and image as an honest man are his assets. But he does not listen to others and has not let his new-found fame sit lightly on his shoulders."

But even as Jarange-Patil and his faction of the NCP. Journalist and political analyst Hemant Desai says Shinde could now use his Maratha support base in seat-sharing negotiations with allies.

At the same time, it has helped Shinde's Sena rein in its senior partner and new-found ally, the Ajit Pawar faction of the NCP. The protesters have targeted both Ajit, a Maratha like Shinde, as well as his fellow deputy CM, the Brahmin Devendra Fadnavis. Despite the NCP's strong Maratha base, Ajit is in a peculiar situation where his party colleague Bhujbal is railing against Jarange-Patil and the Maratha leadership, making everyone wonder whether Bhujbal is the BJP's cat's paw, saying things the party can't. As the BJP eyes OBC support, it grapples with the challenge of addressing simmering resentment within those communities against what they perceive as undue concessions to the Marathas. Former legislator Prakash Shendge's threat to form a separate political front for OBCs underscores the fragility of existing political alliances. ■



Hemant Soren had seen the writing on the wall. Before the Enforcement Directorate (ED) arrested him on the night of January 31 for alleged money-laundering related to the purported possession of a plot of land in Ranchi, the Jharkhand CM had finalised the course of post-crisis political action. A day before, he held a meeting of ruling coalition legislators from the Jharkhand Mukti Morcha (JMM), the Congress and the Rashtriya Janata Dal (RJD) at the CM's office. The solitary agenda was to pick a successor in case the ED arrested him.

Though Soren initially wanted his wife Kalpana Soren to succeed him, he finally agreed on his second choice, old loyalist Champai Soren, 68, for several reasons. Soren's sister-in-law and JMM legislator Sita Soren's opposition to Kalpana's candidature was a minor irritant, but the bigger reason was the possibility of ED action against Kalpana too. Also, she is not an MLA and having a bypoll ahead of the assembly election due late this year may have been iffy. So, Soren had already resigned to this eventuality before submitting his own resignation to Governor C.P. Radhakrishnan at Raj Bhavan on January 31.